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Kinship and marriage among the Nuer

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There are, as we have seen, a very large number of relationships which carry the incest taboo and it is not surprising that there are frequent breaches of it. Indeed, Nuer discuss incest, except incest with the closest kin, without expressing horror or repugnance. It is a fact with which they are familiar and a subject on the surface of life, not a secret thing to be talked of with embarrassment. Parents teach sons at an early age the rules of sex: to avoid the wives of others and women who are kin. Not only must they refrain from making love to women who count as kin but they must avoid any licentious talk, to which the Nuer are much given, in their presence. The *nei ti gwagh*, the unrelated people, they can joke with and make love to without fear of censure or retribution, so long as they are not wives of other men, for fornication with an unrelated girl is not regarded with disapprobation. The admonition of parents is enforced by the frequent discussions children hear about the permissibility of proposed marriages and by the sacrifices on account of incest they are bound to witness from time to time.

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Kinship Regulation Of
Sex

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